

Core Concept

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A small-scale tactical skirmish game with a dungeon-fantasy theming. Aims to combine the fun and expression of deckbuilding in Magic or building a Pokemon team with the gameplay of a tactics game like OPR or FFT. Players control parties of six to ten units on a 48x48-tile map. These units are customizable, using a combination of inventory-slots and a points system. Using alternating unit activations players fight to either wipe out their opponent or to control a majority of points of interest on the map by the end of N rounds (number of rounds is TBD, likely four.) Maps themselves can be player-made, and can have terrain effects that meaningfully impact gameplay decisions.

Core Gameplay Loop:

- Players set up armies—they take turns choosing a unit to deploy from a party they designed ahead of time. They place it somewhere within their deployment zone(48x6 tiles), then the other player goes.
- Eventually, one player will run out of units to place. The remaining player will then place their remaining units. As the last player to act, they will have the first move in the next section.
- We enter the core loop. Players alternate turns activating units until all units have been activated. If a player is out of activate-able units first, their turn ends early and the remaining player finishes activating their units.
 - Activating a unit:
 - The active player selects a unit that has not yet moved this turn.
 - Overall action-economy is similar to Baldurs Gate III—characters have a move action and a main action. They can spend that main action to 'dash' and double their movement. They may have other abilities granted by items that give them an additional bonus action, like drinking a potion.
 - The active player is presented with a choice of using an ability or moving.
 - If they use an ability, they do something tied to the ability. Usually it will be an attack, dealing damage to an enemy at a specified range. Other times it will be something a little more complicated, like a targeted heal or something that moves an enemy around.
 - Combat is done with the attacker rolling 2d10-X (with X starting testing at 10 but likely being closer to 7 or 8), and adding a modifier based off of the quality of their weapon. If they are over the target's armor value.
 - Damage is then rolled based on the weapon type.
 - Armor can either reduce damage inflicted, or reduce likelihood to hit based on the type.
 - If they move, they are able to move a number of squares depending on their movement stat.
 - Movement may be impacted by terrain, with things like forests providing cover or water preventing movement.
 - Movement can also be affected by nearby enemies. Moving out of a square adjacent to an enemy with a melee weapon will give them a free attack.
 - After moving or using an ability, they are offered the opportunity to choose the other option.
 - The unit is marked as having been activated.
 - Once all units have been activated, the round ends. If a player ends the round with a majority of their units within a point of interest's zone of control (likely within two tiles of it), they have captured that point of interest. If a point of interest has an equal amount of units from either side in its zone of control, it is not claimed.

- If N rounds have elapsed, the game ends and the player with more zones of control under their control wins. In the event of a tie, a tie is broken by the point-value of units killed by each player.

Strategic Pillars:

- The player with the better strategy will win the game.
- Units should be customizable, but not overwhelmingly so.
 - This is accomplished by units having four slots for equipment, which also comes at a point cost.
- It is easy to understand a unit's capabilities.
- Maps and terrain meaningfully alter decisions
 - Line of sight for abilities can be blocked by terrain.
 - Chokepoints can make higher-cost units more effective, while open areas put them at a disadvantage when they're swarmed by weaker units.
- Area control > kill count

Unit Roles and Scale:

- Units are named characters defined by a player. They should have enough information for a player to project a personality onto.
- Archetypes, (like striker, support, and tank) should be easy to build
- An average unit should cost about 150 gold
- Units are entirely defined by their equipment.
- Units have 3-6 stats max
- Units have slots for up to four pieces of equipment. These can vary in type and price. For example, a cheap sword might confer a basic melee attack. A health-potion might be consumable to restore their HP. A fancy axe might hit all nearby enemies, and a magic bow might give a stronger ranged attack. Boots might increase movement while a tome might confer a spell. Armor, also, can be purchased to increase health or decrease damage.
- It is likely that equipment and possibly units themselves will be upgradeable. For a comparatively small cost a player can give their unit a +1 sword, but they might find it more cost-effective to increase all of their stats by making them a level 2 unit.
- Abilities are simple and tactical, not like RPG skill trees
- Abilities have infinite uses unless they don't. A grenade is one-use, a spell is not.
- Units can be of varying quality. There should be compelling reasons not to use a single godlike unit or a swarm of terrible units.

What this game is not:

- Not a long-form RPG
- Not an RPG at all. There are probably no levels, and there is definitely no XP gain.
- Not inventory-heavy
- Not a multi-hour battle simulator
- Not deterministic chess

Setup

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- When the game begins, both players will already have selected a 'party' of units.
- For MVC, these units will be predefined.
- Eventually, players will be invited to customize their party prior to play.
- A map is decided on. For MVC there will be one map. For later versions, players will be able to select a map from a collection of premade maps, or upload a map of their own.
- Both players see the map. There is no fog-of-war—they have perfect information from this point on.
- The player with the most units in their army goes first. They choose one unit from their party, and click a tile within six tiles of their edge of the map. That unit has now been placed on the map.
- The other player now takes a turn placing a unit.
- This place/place pattern goes on until both players have fully deployed their army.
- If one player runs out of units, the other player continues deploying solo.
- Whoever places the last unit on the map will go first in the main game loop.

Turn Structure

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- The game is played over four rounds. For a broad summary, players alternate activating units until all units have been activated. The game checks for zone control, and the next round begins.
- Activating a unit:
 - The active player chooses one unit that has not yet been activated.
 - The active player is prompted with the choices to move or to use an ability
 - If the active player chooses to move:
 - Squares on the map where the active unit could move are highlighted.
 - Moveable squares will likely be found using a for-loop keyed to the moving character's movement speed. For each repetition of the loop, all walkable squares orthogonally adjacent to the current set of walkable squares should be added to the set of walkable squares.
 - Squares orthogonally adjacent to an enemy melee unit stop movement. Squares with terrain might be unwalkable, or slow movement.
 - The active player selects which square their character should move to by clicking on it.
 - If there is an orthogonally adjacent enemy unit, that enemy gets a free attack.
 - After moving, if the player has not yet used an ability the player is offered either to 'dash' and move a second time, or to use an ability. After either of these, their turn ends.
 - If the player chooses to use an ability:
 - Some abilities will not have a target, like buffs and self-heals. If one of those is selected, the character performs the associated action.
 - Other abilities will be targeted. Valid targets for the ability will be highlighted for the player to select one. A melee attack would only target orthogonally adjacent enemies, while a ranged attack would target enemies within a certain range that are also in line of sight. A magic spell could still have a range, but ignore cover.
 - If the player has not yet moved, they are offered the opportunity to do so.
- Play passes to the other player. If a player has activated all of their units already, they pass.
- Once all units have been activated, the round ends.
 - All units are marked as not-yet-activated
 - Across the map are three objectives. If a player controls the majority of units near an objective, it is marked as belonging to them.
- The next round begins, starting with the player who most recently activated a unit.
- Once all four rounds are complete, the player who controls the majority of objectives wins.

Unit Stats

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- Core components of a unit. All components can be modified using equipment or abilities:
 - Health: For starters, I'll assume that a unit has five. An 'average' attack should do around three damage.
 - Armor: A single point of armor should make a big difference. Defaults to zero. Armor reduces damage taken by one.
 - Evasion: Similar to armor, one point of evasion is serious. Defaults to zero. Evasion reduces an enemy's Accuracy by one when they attack.
 - ToHit: ToHit is a flat modifier to an attack roll. It defaults to zero.
 - Movement: How far a unit can move when it takes the move action. Defaults to three.
 - Courage: A unit whose courage is low may flee the battlefield when attacked. Courage is a combination of an innate stat (boosted by equipment), but is also dynamically affected by how many enemies and allies are adjacent.

Map/Terrain

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- A map is made up of 48x48 tiles. For current purposes, these tiles can be represented with colored squares.
- A map can be built using a tile-based map editor like Tiled.
- Only one unit can occupy a tile at a time. Tiles containing allies can be passed through, but units cannot end their movement there. Tiles containing enemies are impassable.
- Some map tiles may block ranged attacks. For more of this logic:
 - A unit inside a tile that blocks ranged attacks is still targetable with a ranged attack.
 - A unit cannot make a ranged attack ****through**** a tile that blocks ranged attacks.
 - A unit inside a tile that blocks ranged attacks can make ranged attacks from the tile.
- Tiles can have effects. Here's a starting set of tile types:
 - Grasslands: no effect
 - Forest: +1 evasion, blocks ranged attacks
 - Water: blocks movement, does not block ranged attacks
 - Mountain: Blocks movement and blocks ranged attacks
 - Swamp: Moving through a swamp costs two movement instead of one.

Combat Model

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- Two units are involved in combat: an attacker and a defender
 - There may be a situation where special abilities allow a unit to attack multiple adjacent units. This should be considered a stretch goal.
- The attacker makes a roll to hit. They roll $(2d10-8) + (\text{weapon's attack bonus})$, and compare the result to the defender's evasion. As long as their result is greater than or equal to the defender's evasion, the attack hits. If the attack does not hit, a 'miss' result is displayed and combat ends.
- Damage is rolled. Default damage numbers are $(2d4 - 2) + (\text{weapon's attack bonus}) - (\text{enemy's armor stat})$ rounded up to a minimum of one.
- After taking damage, the defending unit makes a roll to see if they flee. For current purposes, this roll is $(2d6 - 3) - (\text{damage taken}) + (\text{unit's default courage}) - (1 \text{ per adjacent enemy}) + (1 \text{ per adjacent ally})$. If the roll is below the flee threshold (currently defaulting to zero), the unit is removed from the battlefield.

MVC Feature List

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- A map is rendered, with three units on either side and three control points
 - Units are rendered as sprites, but do not yet have animations
 - The map itself is made of tiles, which for now are rendered as blocks of solid colors
 - Units are premade and defined by the programmer.
 - Units' starting positions are defined by the programmer.
- The basic game loop functions
 - Sides alternate moves using the predefined logic.
 - Units can attack one-another, deal damage, and flee the battlefield if defeated
 - Units can only be activated once per round
 - At the end of a round, control points with a majority of one player's units within two tiles are marked as belonging to that player.
 - After four rounds, the game ends and the player with the majority of control points wins.
- Controls are all done with the mouse.